

# This house.



1  
ONCE

**Every cleaning schedule you have ever downloaded was written for a different house**

Somebody else’s weekly list has a conservatory, a utility room and no cat. Yours has whatever it has. Write the rooms down first, with the floor in each one — because the floor decides the method, and half of what goes wrong is a wet mop on wood or a bleach spray on stone.

**THE ROOMS, AND WHAT IS UNDERFOOT**

Floors decide

| ROOM | FLOOR | WHAT MAKES IT HARD |
|------|-------|--------------------|
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |
|      |       |                    |

**WHO LIVES HERE**

Adults

Children

Pets

Anyone home in the day

Asthma, allergies or a baby — changes the products

**WHAT “CLEAN ENOUGH” MEANS HERE**

Agree it, or it is never met

This is the most useful line on the page and the one nobody writes. Two people can keep the same house and be measured against two different standards, neither of them said out loud. Say it out loud.

**BINS AND RECYCLING**

| WHICH | DAY | WHOSE JOB |
|-------|-----|-----------|
|       |     |           |
|       |     |           |
|       |     |           |
|       |     |           |
|       |     |           |
|       |     |           |

**WHERE THE CLEANING THINGS LIVE**

**WHAT WE PAY SOMEBODY ELSE TO DO**

And what it costs

**WHAT IS BROKEN AND KEEPS BEING WORKED AROUND**

# The ten minutes.



2  
DAILY

A house is not kept by deep cleans. It is kept by ten minutes, most evenings.

Not every evening — **most**. The difference between a house that feels fine and one that does not is almost never the Saturday; it is whether the kitchen was cleared before bed. Pick five things, time them once, and stop there when the time is up. The timer is the point: it turns an open-ended, resentful job into a short one with an end.

OUR FIVE Write the minutes in, once you have timed it

| #                   | THE JOB | MINS                 |
|---------------------|---------|----------------------|
| 1                   |         | <input type="text"/> |
| 2                   |         | <input type="text"/> |
| 3                   |         | <input type="text"/> |
| 4                   |         | <input type="text"/> |
| 5                   |         | <input type="text"/> |
| TEN MINUTES, REALLY |         | <input type="text"/> |

STARTED AT, MOST NIGHTS A time beats good intentions

We start at

WHO DOES THE RESET

WHEN THE HOUSE IS FULLER Guests, half-term, after a party

IF THERE IS ONLY TIME FOR ONE OF THE FIVE Which one, and ...

THE WEEK One column per job

| DAY | 1                     | 2                     | 3                     | 4                     | 5                     | NOTE |
|-----|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|------|
| Mon | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |
| Tue | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |
| Wed | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |
| Thu | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |
| Fri | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |
| Sat | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |
| Sun | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> | <input type="radio"/> |      |

THE MORNING VERSION, IF EVENINGS NEVER WORK

WHAT WE LET GO Deliberately, not guiltily

Missing three days does not restart anything and does not mean it failed. The grid is there so you can see that you did it eleven times this month, which is eleven more than the schedule you gave up on in February.

[illegible]

**ADD THE MINUTES UP** — and that is what you are actually asking of a Saturday

Nearly every cleaning schedule fails at the same place: it is a list of jobs with no idea how long they take, so it is agreed to cheerfully and abandoned by eleven o'clock. Time each job once, honestly, and add them up. If the number comes to four hours, you have not got a schedule — you have got a wish, and something on this page has to move to page 5, be done less often, or be done by somebody else.

# Who does what.



4

AGREE IT

**Half the work in a house has no name and nobody thanks you for it**

The cleaning is the visible part. The rest is noticing, remembering, reordering, booking and deciding — and in most houses it is all done by one person who did not volunteer. It cannot be shared out until it is written down, so it is written down here with a name beside it like any other job.

**THE JOBS NOBODY COUNTS**

Put a name against each

THE JOB

WHOSE

Noticing that something has run out, before it runs out

\_\_\_\_\_

Actually buying it

\_\_\_\_\_

Knowing where things live, so they can be put back

\_\_\_\_\_

Booking the boiler, the chimney, the drain, the repair

\_\_\_\_\_

Keeping the bins and the recycling in the right week

\_\_\_\_\_

Holding the whole list in their head, which is a job in itself

\_\_\_\_\_

**THE VISIBLE ONES, THEN**

The circuit on page 3

THE JOB

WHOSE

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

**WHAT EACH OF US WOULD RATHER DO**

It is not all equally hated

WHO

HAPPY TO

WOULD RATHER NOT

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

**CHILDREN, AND WHAT IS ACTUALLY THEIRS**

By age, and meant

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

**REVIEWED EVERY SO OFTEN**

Nothing here is a life sentence

Last talked about

\_\_\_\_\_

Next

\_\_\_\_\_

**WHAT WE CHANGED, AND WHETHER IT HELD**

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

# Monthly, twice a year, once ever.



5  
RARELY

ONCE A MONTH    Date it when it is done

| THE JOB                                                                          | DONE  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Skirting boards, door frames, handles and switches      | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Inside the microwave, and the oven door glass           | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Descale the kettle and the shower head                  | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> A hot empty cycle and the filter on the washing machine | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Test the smoke alarms                                   | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Under the beds, and behind the sofa                     | _____ |

OURS, AS WELL

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

**Three of these are about fire, not tidiness**

Test the smoke alarms monthly and change the batteries yearly. Empty the tumble dryer's lint filter **every single load**, and clean the extractor filter over the hob — both are grease and fluff sitting next to heat. And never leave cloths that have been used with oil screwed up in a warm pile.

TWICE A YEAR    Spring, and before the clocks change

| THE JOB                                                                       | DONE  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Windows, both sides                                  | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Curtains, blinds and the tops of doors               | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> The oven, properly                                   | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Defrost the freezer, and eat what is in it first     | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Mattresses turned, pillows washed                    | _____ |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Gutters, drains and the outside tap before the frost | _____ |

ONCE A DECADE, OR WHEN WE MOVE

\_\_\_\_\_

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\_\_\_\_\_

IT IS FINE TO SKIP    Written down so it stops nagging

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\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

Nobody washes their curtains every month, and a list that says they should is a list that gets thrown away in week three. Put the job on the honest shelf instead: twice a year, once a decade, or never — and then stop carrying it around.

# What not to mix.



| NEVER, IN ANY QUANTITY         |                                                                                                                                | This is the page to photograph |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Bleach + ammonia               | Glass and some multi-surface sprays contain ammonia. Together they give off chloramine. Never in the same sink, bowl or cloth. |                                |
| Bleach + anything acidic       | Vinegar, lemon, limescale removers, some toilet cleaners. Releases chlorine gas.                                               |                                |
| Bleach + surgical spirit       | Or any rubbing alcohol. Do not.                                                                                                |                                |
| Two different drain unblockers | Never one after the other, and never add anything to a pipe that already has one sitting in it.                                |                                |
| Acid on natural stone          | Vinegar and limescale remover etch marble, limestone and travertine permanently. Use something made for stone.                 |                                |
| Anything, in a closed bathroom | Open the window or the door first. Gloves on. Never decant into an unlabelled bottle.                                          |                                |

If something is mixed by accident: leave the room, open the windows from outside if you can, and do not go back in to clear it up. If anybody is coughing or short of breath, get them into fresh air and ring for advice — this kit is not medical advice and does not pretend to be.

Minutes, not adjectives.

**Most houses need four things, not a cupboard full**

Something general for surfaces, something for grease, something for limescale, and good cloths. Everything else is a solved problem being sold twice. Fewer bottles also means fewer chances of two of them meeting.

| WHAT WE ACTUALLY USE |      | And where it is kept  |
|----------------------|------|-----------------------|
| FOR                  | WHAT | LEFT                  |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |
|                      |      | <input type="radio"/> |

**CLOTHS** Colour per room stops the worst of it

**TRIED AND NOT BUYING AGAIN**



## WHAT, AND WHAT TO DO

## WHAT WORKED FOR US

Cold water only — heat sets protein. Then an enzyme detergent. Never hot.

Blot hard, do not rub. Dilute with cold water, blot again, then a stain remover. Salt is folklore; blotting is the work.

Absorb first with bicarb or cornflour, brush off, then washing-up liquid on what is left.

Cloth underneath, dab with surgical spirit from the back, small area at a time, changing the cloth as it lifts.

Cold water straight away, then detergent. On washables, a vinegar rinse helps — not on wool.

Harden it with ice, scrape off the ridge, then brown paper and a warm iron to draw the rest out.

Blot, then an

cleaner. Nothing ammonia-based — it smells like the reason they went there in the first place.

Let it dry completely. Brush it off. Then wash. Working it wet spreads it into the fibres.

Work from the outside of the mark inwards, or you spread it. **Blot, never rub** — rubbing pushes it into the fibres and roughs them up. And test anything new on a hidden corner first, because the second stain is the one you made yourself.

## WHAT WE KEEP FOR IT, AND WHERE

## TAKEN TO A PROFESSIONAL

Some things are worth not ...



A whole house in two days is why it does not happen at all. One room a month is twelve rooms a year, it fits in an afternoon, and it means every room gets properly done once — which is more than a spring clean has managed in most houses since the last time somebody moved.

| MONTH     | ROOM | DONE | ✓                        |
|-----------|------|------|--------------------------|
| January   |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| February  |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| March     |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| April     |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| May       |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| June      |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| July      |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| August    |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| September |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| October   |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| November  |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| December  |      |      | <input type="checkbox"/> |

## WHAT WE FOUND WE DO NOT NEED AT ALL

# What it actually took.



**TIMED, NOT GUESSED** Then correct page 3

| DATE | WHAT GOT DONE | MINS                 |
|------|---------------|----------------------|
|      |               | <input type="text"/> |
|      |               | <input type="text"/> |
|      |               | <input type="text"/> |
|      |               | <input type="text"/> |
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Do this for a fortnight and the numbers on page 3 stop being guesses. Almost everybody is wrong in the same direction: the small jobs take four minutes rather than fifteen, and the ones that are put off for months take eleven.

**The job you keep putting off is usually not the job**

It is a missing bin, a shelf that is too high, a cupboard you have to empty to get into, or a decision nobody has made. Write down **why** beside it rather than just writing it down again — half of them turn out to be a five-pound fix rather than a failure of character.

| <b>KEEPS GETTING PUT OFF — AND WHY</b> |                   |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------|
| THE JOB                                | THE ACTUAL REASON |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |
|                                        |                   |

| <b>WORTH PAYING SOMEBODY FOR</b> | Hours, times what yo... |
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| <b>WHAT WE CHANGED, AND WHETHER IT HELD</b> |
|---------------------------------------------|
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